WASHINGTON

The Evergreen State



The Pacific Northwest has always been defined by its rivers. The Columbia, the Skagit, the Quinault—these waterways carved the landscape and fed the people who lived along them for thousands of years. For the Indigenous nations of what is now Washington State—the Chinook, the Makah, the Tulalip, and dozens more—salmon was not simply food. It was ceremony, economy, and identity, returning each year in numbers so vast that early explorers described the rivers as appearing to boil with fish.

The technique of cooking salmon over cedar was born from both necessity and brilliance. Cedar trees grew in extraordinary abundance throughout the coastal forests of the Pacific Northwest, their wood fragrant, rot-resistant, and readily available. Indigenous cooks learned early that the oils in cedar smoke did something extraordinary to salmon flesh—infusing it with a warm, resinous perfume that complemented the fish's natural richness without overwhelming it. Whole sides of salmon were traditionally lashed to split cedar stakes and angled toward open fires along the riverbanks, a method that allowed the heat to move slowly and evenly through the thick flesh. It was patience turned into flavor.

When British and American explorers arrived in the late 1700s, they encountered communities along Puget Sound and the Olympic Peninsula that had refined this cooking tradition over countless generations. The Lewis and Clark Expedition, which reached the Columbia River in 1805, documented in detail the salmon-centered culture of the Chinook people—their sophisticated trade networks, their methods of preservation, and the central role the fish played in every aspect of life. What the journals could not fully capture was the smell of cedar smoke drifting over the water at dusk, or the way a perfectly cooked salmon pulled apart in the firelight.

As Washington Territory grew through the 19th century and canneries rose along the Columbia and the Sound, salmon became both a regional staple and a commercial engine. Scandinavian and Finnish immigrants who settled the fishing communities of the coast brought their own deep reverence for smoked fish, and they recognized immediately in the cedar plank tradition something that resonated with their own culinary heritage. The technique became shared, adapted, and eventually embraced across the region as a mark of Pacific Northwest identity.

What you are about to make carries all of that history in its simplicity. The cedar plank fills your kitchen with the scent of an old-growth forest meeting the sea. The salmon—ideally a wild Pacific king or sockeye—cooks gently over the coals, drinking in that smoke until every bite is silky, fragrant, and deeply satisfying. This is a dish that asks very little of the cook and rewards the table enormously. Soak the plank, light the grill, and let a few thousand years of Pacific Northwest wisdom do the rest.

SERVING SUGGESTION

Serve cedar-planked salmon with roasted seasonal vegetables, wild rice, or a fresh green salad for a true Pacific Northwest dining experience.

CEDAR-PLANKED SALMON WITH HONEY-BALSAMIC GLAZE

Cedar smoke and a honey-balsamic glaze turn Northwest salmon into something elegant, ancient, and unmistakably Washington.

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

SALMON

- 2 lb. fresh salmon fillet, skin-on
- 1 cedar plank, soaked in water for at least 2 hours
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 Tbsp olive oil

HONEY-BALSAMIC GLAZE

- ¼ cup honey
- 2 Tbsp balsamic vinegar
- 1 Tbsp tamari (or coconut aminos)
- 1 tsp Dijon mustard
- ½ tsp minced garlic
- Pinch of crushed red pepper (optional, for subtle heat)

TO FINISH

- Fresh thyme, parsley, or lemon wedges, for garnish (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Soak the plank*: Submerge the cedar plank in water for at least 2 hours (weight it down so it stays under).
2. *Preheat grill*: Preheat your grill to medium heat (375–400°F, or 190–204°C).
3. *Prepare the glaze*: In a small saucepan over low heat, combine honey, balsamic vinegar, tamari, Dijon mustard, garlic, and crushed red pepper. Simmer gently for 3–4 minutes until slightly thickened. Remove from heat and set aside.
4. *Prepare the plank*: Brush cedar plank lightly with olive oil. Place salmon skin-side down on the plank. Season with salt and pepper.
5. *Glaze the salmon*: Set a small portion of glaze aside in a clean bowl, then brush the rest generously over the salmon.
6. *Grill*: Place the plank on the preheated grill. Close the lid and cook for 20–25 minutes, depending on the thickness of the fillet, until salmon flakes easily with a fork and reaches an internal temperature of 145°F (63°C).
7. *Finish*: Brush with remaining glaze and optional garnishes just before serving.

